Congress. In Jharkhand, too, the Congress may be offered only a token seat of its 14 Lok Sabha seats. In Maharashtra, where the Congress was the junior partner in the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi alliance that included the Shiv Sena and Nationalist Congress Party, it can now expect a role reversal following the split in both parties. The allies may not take kindly to the rejig, exposing further areas of confrontation. The only state where there may be a peaceful seat-sharing arrangement is Tamil Nadu where the Congress is at the mercy of the DMK.

This also means the possibility of 'electorally effective' seat-sharing between the Congress—the only party that has a presence in all nine states—and other partners is dim at present. It's no surprise then that the alliance partners were quick to distance themselves from the results of the state elections, saying the BJP's victory was not a defeat of INDIA but only of the Congress. "The setback should be seen as a setback for the Congress, not for the INDIA alliance," NC leader Omar Abdullah said.

CONGRESS HAS THE KEY

Despite such posturing, the prospect of INDIA getting the better of the BJP-led NDA (National Democratic Alliance) largely hinges on Congress performance, particularly in states where it's in direct combat with the BJP. The majority of these states are in the Hindi heartland. In six states accounting for 100 seats—Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP and Chhattisgarh—the Congress is the prime challenger to the BJP. In Karnataka, which has 28 seats, the Congress is the only INDIA party, with the Janata Dal (Secular) joining the NDA. Together, in these 128 seats, the Congress won only four in 2019. This, despite the fact that it had formed government in three of them—Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh—just months before in December 2018. This time, it has lost all three.

The last time the Congress was in such a precarious position was in 1998 when Sonia Gandhi took charge of the party. Then it was in power in just one state in the north, MP, while the total tally was three states, including Odisha and Mizoram. Currently, it's in power in three states—Himachal Pradesh, Telangana and Karnataka—which account for 50 LS seats. It's also a junior partner in Bihar and Jharkhand, two states with 54 seats in the lower house.

The direct contests in the north Indian states have given the BJP a distinct advantage. In the 186 Lok Sabha seats where the two are pitted against each other, the Congress won only 15 in 2019. The eventual outcome of 2024 will depend on what happens in these 186 Lok Sabha seats. The party's abysmal performance is not restricted to Lok Sabha elections, where it won a total of 44 seats in 2014 and 52 in 2019. In assembly polls, too, its strike rate is diminishing. Between 2014 and 2018, it won 32 per cent of the state polls it contested. But from 2019 to 2023, the success rate came down to 26 per cent.



ANI

THE CONGRESS NEEDS A NARRATIVE THAT CATCHES THE VOTERS' FANCY. EVEN RAHUL GANDHI'S 'BHARAT JODO' YATRA FOUND LITTLE RESONANCE IN THE HEARTLAND STATES



For a turnaround, the Congress first needs an organisational shake-up to facilitate a generational change in state leadership. In both MP and Rajasthan, Kamal Nath and Ashok Gehlot—both septuagenarian—opted for their traditional electoral model, ignoring the plans chalked out by strategist Sunil Kanugolu. In contrast, in Telangana 54-year-old Revanth Reddy brought fresh energy while Kanugolu's inputs helped hone the strategy. The Congress also needs a narrative that catches the voters' fancy. The promise of welfare schemes and cash doles earned it success in Karnataka, but the BJP soon came up with its own versions in this round of state polls. Personal attacks on PM Narendra Modi have proved to be counterproductive. Rahul Gandhi's narrative of spreading love and social inclusivity, as against the BJP's alleged communal agenda, has also found little resonance in the heartland states.